

Things that have helped me FUNCTION much much MUCH better with ADHD. (Abridged)

Here are the things that have helped me function MUCH better that you can give a try.

Some background info about me for context:

I'm a university student that only got properly diagnosed two years ago, but whether I knew it or not I have been trying to deliberately deal with my ADHD since middle school. So though I have implemented a lot of the more conventional and typical advice I still found them wanting. And it wasn't until recently that I am able to be as functional as I'd like.

This will be a compilation of stuff that helped me a lot to get to this point, this might be a lot of information, so you can just pick and choose which area is most relevant.

Disclaimer though, I'm not a professional and these are just the things that have helped me in my experience, your experience might differ but I do hope at least some of it might be useful to you.

At the end of the day what matters is what works for you.

Biological Related Things

I'd consider this area the foundation of everything and it's probably the area that helped me the most and gave me the biggest leverage. Settling things related to this area made everything else I do much easier and sustainable.

Medication

I found that a combination of stimulant and non-stimulant medication worked best for me.

I titrated and experimented a lot to find the right medication, but eventually was able to settle on a combination and routine that alleviated friction as much as possible.

Though stimulant medication helped with focus and doing tasks I noticed that I still struggled with doing more "minor" activities such as chores and basic self-care, so I decided to bring up the idea to my psychiatrist to give non-stimulants a try.

The non-stimulant helped me with the ability to do more varied things during the day, but without the stimulants I still had difficulty doing mentally intense activities; so combining both seems to have addressed both my issues with directing focus and doing things, as well as reducing issues with shifting focus and having the mental energy for more minor tasks.

Note: During this period I had days and even weeks where I was barely able to function during the titration period. So please be very careful if you are planning to do this and work with a professional.

Electrolytes

Before I took electrolytes I frequently felt completely burnt out and unable to function despite taking medication, eating enough, and drinking a lot of water.

It's possible this is due to just me living in a tropical region and sweating a lot, but I found that it helped when my medication isn't working for whatever reason.

I just take electrolytes through a tablet that you mix with water.

As for when I take it, I usually just take it after a workout or if I feel weirdly dysfunctional despite having done the usual things such as eating properly and taking medication.

Complex Carbohydrates

I noticed that despite everything I still felt somewhat exhausted with very limited bandwidth throughout the day, though not as completely dysfunctional as I was before taking the electrolytes.

I noticed that my brain craved a lot of carbs, but it wasn't until adding much more complex carbohydrates to my diet that the cravings stopped. Doing this has also helped a lot with my mental stamina and feeling like I can get through not just the immediate day, but also tomorrow, and the day after that.

So for example, before this I would eat rice, potatoes, bread etc. but it wasn't until I ate oatmeal as the main source of my carbohydrates that the days become much easier to go through.

Instant Oats + Milk is my main breakfast now and I also eat it in between stimulant doses. I also just eat it if I suddenly feel very exhausted or mentally fatigued, seems to help a lot.

Other Nutrients

I notice that after addressing the above I sometimes still have weird issues due to nutrition deficiencies that I didn't know I had (e.g. weird sensations on my tongue due to an iron deficiency). So if something feels or seems off, it might be worth checking or trying to address it.

In the case of my weird symptoms for example, I assumed I had an iron deficiency, so I just ate some canned sardines, beans, and fried eggs. The symptoms dialed down after a day or so.

Resting

For the longest time I've struggled finding what helps me to rest and recover during the day outside of sleep, but the things that have worked best for me during the worst of it and still works for me now are taking a break from any kinds of stimulation (e.g lights, screens, sounds, information) and let myself wind down or even just take a nap if I'm feeling really tired.

Another thing I noticed is that for my mind to feel rested, whatever the activity is, It needs to be low intensity but also make my mind feel like time is moving very slowly. For example, if I watch a youtube

video time moves very fast in my mind, but if I just stare out the window, it might feel like it takes forever, but if I look at the clock only 5 or 10 minutes have passed. Whatever it is, experiencing this feeling seems to be what rejuvenates me personally.

Additionally, after settling problems with my medication and general nutrition I've been able to rest much more reliably and recover faster, and of course, it likely helped that the medication made "sitting still" not feel completely impossible.

From what I see though, everyone seems to rest differently so use whatever works for you as long as it makes you reliably able to tackle whatever it is next you need to do.

Note: In my experience finding a reliable way to rest is as important or even more important than being able to just do or power through things. Stress and willpower helped me a lot in the short-term, but it wasn't until addressing rest that I can confidently tackle longer-term goals and sustain them. Also, chronic stress is no joke, so please listen to your body if you feel like you need a break when possible rather than powering through. I've seen stories of people pushing themselves to a point beyond repair.

Example:



📌 Pinned by How to ADHD

@soozarty 1 year ago

I'm the cautionary warning of pushing yourself too hard. I loved my job as a bereavement counselor. I specialized in young adult grief. I developed programs, presented to National orgs and provided grief support for my clients. I was also working on a book chapter. Factor in an unhealthy management team with an unrealistic and nearly impossible system to earn raises each year. Additionally, to counter balance the intense emotional work (and make enough money to live in the Bay Area) I also stage managed concerts and award shows on weekends and occasionally after work and wrote for a music publication. I found myself pushing harder and harder and I **did** break. I ignored the symptoms you mentioned-forgetfulness, word seeking issues, fatigue, etc. and kept pushing until my autonomic nervous system literally broke. My heart rate and blood pressure rose and fell like a roller coaster. I was passing out and having falls. I was so fatigued I could barely get out of bed. If I stood up, my HR and BP would sky rocket to dangerous levels. If I tried to walk or exercise, it would go so high I would pass out. I used to run 6 miles before work every morning, lead hikes throughout the Bay Area, and dance regularly. After doctors at UCSF, Stanford, and Pittsburgh couldn't diagnose me, I was accepted at Mayo Clinic for a week where I was diagnosed with Hyperadrenergic Dysautonomia. Burn out is very real and stress is not something to take lightly. In our culture, it has seriously been downplayed, but the reality is that stress can cause serious and permanent health issues. I now walk (short distances) with a cane so I don't fall over, am on permanent disability, and am having to find new passions because my old ones aren't possible for me to do anymore. Financially, I'm having to live on a fraction of what I earned before I got sick. I'm glad you listened to your body. I wish I had listened to mine.

Sleep

I find that the common advice of getting at least 6 to 8 hours of sleep everyday is important to function well throughout the day. But the main issue for me has been sleeping on time consistently and waking up reliably, and most importantly having it be sustainable. I'm currently still ironing this out for myself, but here are a few things that helped me a lot so far.

Things that help for sleeping when I want to:

1. Not taking stimulant medication past 6pm. I notice that I end up feeling not sleepy at all until around 4 am if I do take stimulant medication past that time.
2. I kinda just accepted for now that I can't really go to sleep on demand the usual way (such as just waiting for myself to sleep after ten minutes) so what I notice helped for me was having something familiar playing in the background as I drift to sleep. For example, a long video essay I listened to previously or a familiar lecture. In my experience familiar music didn't help that much.
3. Blue light filters on devices and monitors, it's didn't make as much of a difference as the above in my experience, but I do notice it helps me feel much more sleepy when bed time rolls around.

Things that help for waking up when I want to:

1. Having multiple alarms at 30 minute intervals on my phone helped a lot for me, additionally having a physical alarm clock also helps if I need the redundancy.
2. I notice that ideally it's better for myself to be able to wake up in some "morning" (5 a.m - 7 a.m) range without an alarm on my own (such as on weekends), but having multiple alarms do still help a lot for days with morning classes or appointments though.

Fixing Sleep Schedules:

After a lot of experimentation, a consistent and reliable way for me to fix a poor sleep schedule does seem to be trying to make myself sleep at and wake up at the same time consciously and deliberately for 2 weeks or so. Even if I don't end up sleeping or waking up at the set time, the earnest attempt to sleep earlier and wake up earlier seems to work over time.

A lot of physical activity during the day also helps from my experience.

Psychological Related Things

This is gonna be full of areas relating to the subjective experience of having or doing things with ADHD. Though common advice such as timers, deadlines, and others help, it didn't seem to help my issue that things still felt *agonising* to do despite being able to do the work, so this is dedicated to things that do help with decreasing that agony. This in turn makes doing things more consistently much easier.

Decreasing Boredom, Emotional Distress and General Suffering

These are things that personally make doing day to day tasks not feel completely draining or stressful.

Addressing Biological Related Things

Looking back at the past ten years of me trying every tool, system, advice, and behavioral changes for ADHD, genuinely nothing else has made as big of an impact as finally identifying and addressing the biological related things that serve as a foundation for everything else.

In my experience addressing these areas have made it much MUCH easier to sustain good habits and fulfilling responsibilities, but of course addressing these alone aren't sufficient so further below are some other things that have helped me in functioning better.

Music/Podcasts/Background Noise

In my experience, how helpful these are generally does depend. I had thought that since I'm on medication I wouldn't really need them, but I find that even with meds they still help in getting myself to start or sustaining less mentally intense activities such as chores.

For activities such as studying I notice that they don't really help and lead to less quality learning, but listening to something during breaks or in-between study sessions do help break up the monotony.

For when doing work such as writing, I do notice that while having music or background noise in the phase of planning doesn't help, after setting up the foundation and outline, having noise in the background does help just putting the words on the page.

Another thing I notice is that in the rare times that background noise doesn't help where I expect it to, taking a break from it helps me in doing activities weirdly enough, so I just adjust as needed.

Reading and Watching at Faster Speed

I found that for lectures, if they are in video format it helps me if I speed them up in parts I can already make sense and understand, while slowing it down to normal speed for parts that are much more dense.

Additionally, if I need something from a written material and I can't find what I need by just jumping around the text or skimming, I found that forcing myself a bit to just read it linearly but *faster* so I don't get mentally bogged down helps.

For truly dense written material such as technical manuals and textbooks I find that just slowly working through it and taking notes helps the most.

Thinking in Terms of Probabilities & Presence Rather than Only Cause & Effect

From my own experience it helped me to also think about how the presence of an item, behavior, or medication helped improve my quality of life and increase the probability of better outcomes rather than just thinking in normal cause and effect.

For example, with my ADHD medication there were times where I was still functional when I didn't have it, or still dysfunctional when I did have it, and it made me ponder a lot if I "truly" needed them, since I thought:

"Now that I'm finally medicated I **should** be able to do [activity] with complete reliability, so why am I still unable to do this?"

or

"Oh, there's a brief moment where I can do things **without** the medication, maybe I don't need them after all and just need to find a way to completely function without them!"

In the end though, I realised that regardless of their complete reliability, my life improved a lot more since I had them compared to when I didn't. So now I try to use a similar lens to evaluate other things that help me with my day.

Exercising Discernment and Adjusting Approaches

Another thing that helped me is to remind myself sometimes to deliberately reflect and consider the context of the immediate situation and then commit to an action, rather than constantly relying on (or trying to find) one fixed method or principle.

For example, before being on medication, negative emotions and stress were the only reliable way for me to do things, but this led to frequent burnout. And even after being on medication, I kept trying to rely on stress for everything since I didn't want to risk the possibility of *not* doing the thing I wanted to do. But... I realised that despite having relied on it for years, and even with the support of medication, my capacity to do things sustainably has not gotten better, so I decided to find ways that didn't just rely on pure stress.

What I use now is basically everything I've written in this document, but I've also realised at times I overcorrected and became too afraid to exert even a little bit of stress to do things, so now I just try to reflect and adjust as needed, rather than trying to rigidly use only stress or only stress-free methods.

I do find this is most relevant when I was building a new habit or skill, as well as when I still haven't found extremely reliable methods to get things done. The tool, method, or strategy had to be adjusted from day to day, but as progress is made, over time my consistency and reliability did improve without the need for constant improvisation. Be it due to familiarity, better methods, or addressing underlying causes.

Managing Working Memory

There's this concept in psychology called working memory (WM), you can think of it as the "RAM" of the human mind, it's what lets us manipulate and process things in just our head, and it's commonly said we can only hold 4-7 "chunks" of information before it gets overwhelming, and in people with ADHD the WM tends to be overloaded pretty fast, so in my experience conscious management of how I use mine helps a lot.

One common strategy is to deliberately externalise working memory. For example: writing things out on paper, breaking things down to smaller steps, and using simpler words. And they are very useful, but there are some moments where these techniques break down for me. Moments such as: reading a particularly dense text, trying to solve a novel problem, studying a complex subject, starting a completely new project. I find that in situations like these, even when using the common advice my working memory still felt overwhelmed.

What I did find work for me is consciously and deliberately keeping things out of my working memory, in essence knowing (or choosing) what specific aspect to purposefully think about and purposefully *not* to think about for a given subject.

So what do I mean by this in practice? For example if I find myself overwhelmed on what to do or where to get started, I try to deliberately make myself focus on ONE thing and purposefully exclude every other aspect, even if my mind feels it is relevant.

As a concrete example, I had extreme difficulty memorising material before, but if I now had to memorise something like cell organelles, I'd do something like this:

1. Look at list of organelles and their functions.
2. Look away and try to rewrite it in a blank page without seeing the answer.
3. If nothing comes up I deliberately pick ONE to keep in my head. For example "smooth endoplasmic reticulum."
4. If even "smooth endoplasmic reticulum" is too much I deliberately pick ONE part to remember in my head. In this case "smooth."
5. Once I am able to rewrite at least one part without looking, I slowly continue the process until my brain is able to speed up and link them together.
6. Eventually I'll be able to write in the blank paper "smooth endo...." then "smooth endoplas..." and then "smooth endoplasmic reticulum functions as..." and so on..

Another example, I am currently self-studying linear algebra following an online course, and in one of the [videos](#) a problem came up, it went like this:

"The complete solution to...

$$Ax = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 4 \\ 1 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

is...

$$x = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix} + c \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 2 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

what can you say about the columns of A?"

When I first tried solving it I felt immediately overwhelmed and lost on where to begin despite having able to solve previous problems using the involved concepts.

I simultaneously thought multiple things like:

- "Hrm, just how many am I expected to say?"
- "Oh this concept and that concept can work... but how do I know if I exhausted all the possible things I can say?"
- "wait what even does complete solution mean here? I've never heard of that before... and how do I know if what I'm listing is even correct in the first place?"

It wasn't until I purposefully reminded myself to just pick ONE thing to think of that I made progress in solving it.

In this case, for the first step I deliberately tried to limit my thinking to *only* how the resulting matrix Ax has 4 rows, and how the matrix in x only has 3 rows, which means it's likely that A has 4 rows for the output to be possible. That's one thing I can say about the columns of A , and throughout this process I force myself to not care about any other information or possibility.

Next I move on to how there are only 3 rows in x . Since matrix multiplication requires the number of columns in A to match the number of rows in x , it's likely that A has 3 columns. That's the second thing I can say about the columns of A .

From here, it became smoother to solve the problem and I didn't have to deliberately limit my thinking as much.

Another example, my friends and I were playing a [puzzle game](#) and the puzzle went like this:

You are working on creating a map of a small, cubical Planet. The map has been folded out so the six sides lie flat.

All you need to do is fill in the squares to complete the map. Rotate and Place the Pieces so that the roads on the assembled map all connect properly. There will be one piece left over at the end, of course.

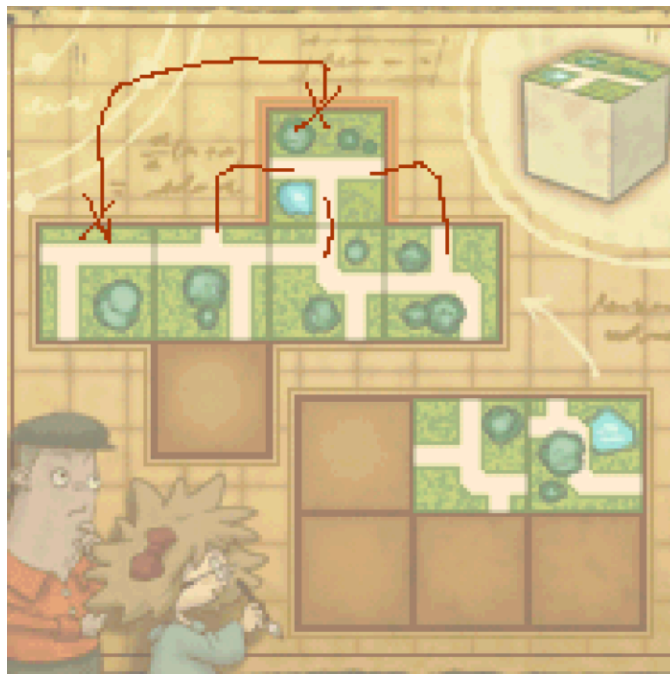


We mulled over this for quite a bit, even one of my friends using q 3D Modeling Software to see the resulting cube wasn't quite enough to solve the thing immediately.

What we figured out so far was that:

- 1. The starting piece is fixed so we don't have to worry about that.
- 2. The left most piece can't have a road pointing up, as it won't connect with the starting piece.
- 3. The three blank spaces connected to the starting piece has to have roads in the middle to connect properly.

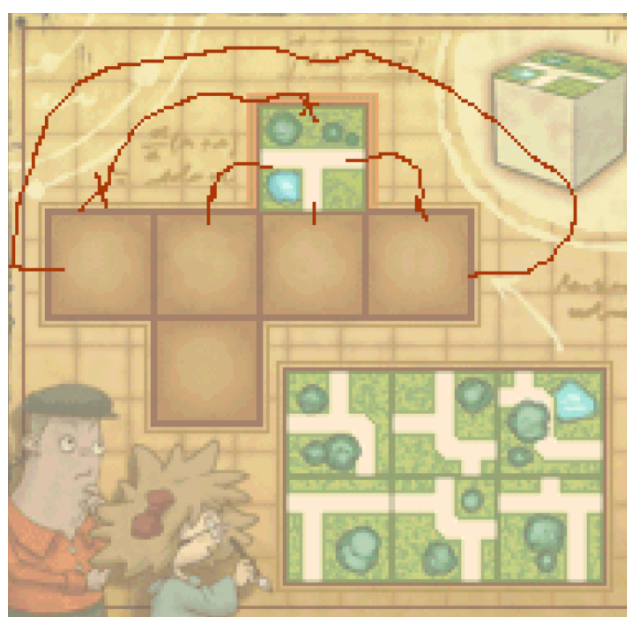
It looked something like this so far:



But no matter what we did we can't seem to be able to solve it, there just seemed to be too many possible arrangements left. In my mind, it felt quite overwhelming to try and solve this puzzle even with externalisation methods and I realise that this felt similar to times where my WM was overloaded. So, what I decided to do was find ways to make it fit easier in my mind.

What I tried was deliberately limiting myself to not think about visualising the rotation of the cube, or think of a cube in general. Instead trying to find extremely simple ways to conceptualise it. This came about in two ways for me:

- 1. Instead of trying to think of the full cube with its rotations, I can just think of which sections will connect to each other. Looking something like this in my head:



- 2. Instead of trying to look at how everything connects to which, I can separate them into close connections, and farther connections, and mentally folding only certain portions of the cube, rather than the whole thing. Looking something like this:

(from top to bottom, close connections and far connections respectively)



From here it was much simpler to go about finding pieces and rotations that would fit. And after a bit more trial and error with adjustments, it finally resulted in:



which thankfully was the correct solution:



I find that there are a lot of other applications for this, from figuring out how to draw a completely novel object or when slowly chipping away at a long-term project. The idea is to just purposefully reduce the load on the working memory until I have a *very* clear mental image that I can work with, even if it is stupid simple, rather than only trying to intuitively feel my way through things. The stimulant medication in particular helps me a lot in doing these kinds of things.

Support Systems

For me, I've found it to be very helpful to have at least one person where I can talk about my unfiltered difficulties, frustrations, and general feelings about having ADHD; someone who is willing to listen and attentively respond with empathy and support.

It may be worth to consider disclosing your ADHD or struggles in general to someone who you really REALLY trust, or consider having a therapist to support you. Having some social and emotional support helped make things less maddening when I was still figuring out what worked for me, so maybe it will for you too.

Behavioral Related Things

This is going to be full of things relating to executing tasks and building routine, but also the typical "planner", "pomodoro", "timer", related stuff concerning ADHD that I use.

General Tools

There's a lot of general advice about using these types of tools if one has ADHD so feel free to just skim this part. The general idea is to just add friction to stuff I want to do less, while making it easier to do things I want to do more.

1. Calendars and Timeblocking

I personally use google calendar since it can notify me and sync with every device and application that supports it. It also has recurring events so it can automatically remind of things such as a weekly meetings without needing to set new reminders all the time.

Also, instead of having a strict schedule I just use the concept of "Timeblocking" (e.g from 4 p.m to 7 p.m I have it dedicated to "Studying", but whether I study for all that time or what kind of subject is up to me, as long as I used some portion of that time period to study. I find that it helps give enough structure in my day while also giving some leeway.

2. Timers and Alarms

I use a lot of timers and alarms for different things since I find them easy and convenient for reminding me of things. I just use the default alarm that comes with my phone.

I typically set my phone alarm to ring 15 minutes before the the set time and I adjust this buffer depending on the activity. For example, if a class is at 8 am, i set my alarm to ring at 7:45 am. And if an activity is *VERY* important, I set multiple alarms at 30 minute intervals before the actual start of the activity. For example, if I have a flight to catch and need to go to the airport at 3pm, I have alarms set to ring at 1 pm, 1:30 pm, and so on to remind me to start packing or whatever else I need to do.

For timers I use two things. One is the default one that comes with my phone, I use it to set a timer that counts down as soon as I take my medication. For example, as soon as I take my stimulant medication I set a timer set to ring after 4 hours since that's the typical duration of the medication. Similarly, for my non-stimulant medication I have it set to ring after 24 hours have elapsed since I'm just meant to take it once in the morning. I found that this helps me keep track of how much "medicated time" I have left. And since I usually vary in when I take my medication, it helps keep track of whether I need to take it again or if I can just wait.

For the second timer I use an app called "Simple Time Tracker" to quantify how much time I spend doing things. It's mostly there to record how much time I spend in an activity when I'm experimenting or trying

a new method, and sometimes as a pseudo-pomodoro timer just to keep me on track. I find that recording the time elapsed since I've started an activity helps to gauge whether I want to keep pushing or take a break and come back later. This app in particular is nice since I can get an overview of recorded performance in the week or month. Tracking 24/7 definitely is a bit too much for me though, so I typically just track important activities or track every activity for just one week to see how I'm currently doing.

3. Agendas and Reminders

For keeping track of things I need to do I just use the default notes app in my phone. I find that it helps to just write the bare minimum + deadline. Additionally, having sticky notes and whiteboards to write and make "physical" important information also helps.

For VERY important activities, just adding a bunch of reminders everywhere both digital and physical works for me. For example, I'll have reminders related to a big project scattered throughout all my devices, as well as around my room using the sticky notes + whiteboards.

P.S digital sticky notes for PC are also a thing should you need it.

4. Adblock and Other Useful Browser Extensions

The internet is very cool, but a lot of things are specifically designed to keep someone scrolling and capture their attention, so I wanted to eliminate as much of them as possible. Here's what I use (I personally use Mozilla Firefox):

- **An adblocker**

Pretty sure everyone has one these days but still worth mentioning.

- **"Unhook"**

Hides a bunch of attention grabbing stuff on YouTube such as recommended videos, shorts, comments and homepage suggestions (fully configurable). I use online lectures on YouTube a lot, so something like this helps me stay on track.

5. Mobile Phone Modifications

I use my smartphone a lot, but similar to the internet, a bunch of stuff is designed to keep someone's attention longer than they might have wanted to. Here's what I use (I personally use an Android phone):

- **Disabling most notifications**

I personally disable most sound and push notifications for any app I use, the only one's I leave on are notifications from friends and family, as well as work e-mail.

- **Uninstalling unnecessary social media**

I don't really use Instagram or the like and I usually just reinstall it if I want to see what my friends are doing.

- **Scroll Blockers and Screen Time Limiters**

There are apps that disables the endless scrolling and short-form content found in stuff like Instagram and Reddit, as well as blocks the use of an app after an allocated time has passed. I personally use "ScreenZen" and "ScrollGuard".

- **Alternative Phone Homepages**

There are options to make the phone much more minimalist and less distracting (on Android at least) with just one app. I currently use "Niagara Launcher", but "minimalist phone" was also pretty good.

6. Miscellaneous Tools

Random stuff I find useful.

- **Extension Cords**

I use electronic devices a lot, and forcing myself to go to one spot over and over again to charge something when drained can feel impossible at times, so having some around to charge wherever is quite nice.

- **Binder Notebooks**

I prefer physical notetaking, but using a whole notebook feels too restrictive and annoying. Using a binder lets me add and remove random notes whenever.

- **E-Ink Tablet**

Genuinely one of the most expensive things I've ever bought, but helped me a lot. It's basically all the convenience of having digital notes on a tablet while still having the feel of physical handwriting. It's also minimalist enough to not be a second phone. I personally use this to save physical space since it can act as an e-reader for a bunch of different textbooks as well notetaking for a lot of different subjects. I personally use the BOOX Go 10.3.

- **Weighted Blanket**

Can be quite pricey, but using it now and again does feel restorative. Not as reliably game changing as the other stuff mentioned in my experience though.

Note: Ideally, using these tools will be as intuitive and unintrusive as possible, and take as little mental energy or willpower whenever possible. I've found that if after a week or two using a tool feels like too much hassle I can drop it, or keep it around but not feel compelled to use it everyday.

Self-Care, Building Routine and Making Changes

It took me much longer than I thought (and would like) to make certain habits less effortful, and it wasn't until I sorted out the biological stuff that they became truly sustainable. For example, brushing teeth consistently is a common gripe with ADHD, and it wasn't until four months ago that I can safely say I began to make it stick. Here's some of the stuff I find helpful for things like this:

- **Sorting Out the Biological Stuff**

I definitely sound like a broken record at this point, but genuinely, finding things like food that truly feel mentally restorative for me has been game changing. The usual stuff like meds and sleep help too of course.

- **Spending an entire day's worth of mental energy**

Personally when building a new habit I kinda had to pick a safe day to do it for the first day, since in my experience, if I really went out of my way to build a new habit from scratch, I wouldn't have the mental energy to do anything else taxing for the day. And it took me around... two months or so before it became noticeably less taxing.

Note: I didn't have to be insanely consistent in doing the habit for those two months, but I did try to make it the main activity to do for the day and deliberately kept it in mind, even if I don't end up doing it or if the time of day I did them in varied.

For example when I was building the habit of VERY consistent tooth brushing, one day I might brush my teeth at 10 pm, and another my brain might act up and it won't take me until 3 am to be able to do it, but if the possibility is there (even if the timing is very weird) I just take it.

P.S periods like semester breaks and long holidays were great as a safety net when going through the exhausting first few weeks of building a habit.

- **Doing It Whenever Possible**

I notice that when building a new habit there would be times my brain feels compelled to do it even if it isn't in the usual schedule; be it a chore, self-care activity, or exercise. For example, I usually do laundry once a week on the weekend, but as I was building the habit I might feel to do it twice a week, or even the day after I had just done it. Letting myself follow this impulse seems to help make it stick.

- **Accepting Doing It Consciously and Deliberately**

From what I can tell, even when the habits do become less mentally taxing to initiate over time, they still have to be done consciously and deliberately, and never do become fully "automatic" the way others seem to describe it. Thankfully the ability to do it consciously does get easier, and I will get the impulse to do them over time even if it takes deliberate thought. From here, I just decided the strategy is to find ways to rest and be mentally "fresh" so I can keep making deliberate actions.

- **Making It Give Sooner Feedback**

I find that for something to stick and be sustainable, I need to feel its immediate effects somewhat and know the methods that make that immediacy possible.

For example, for something like weight training, my workouts didn't feel rewarding or its effects immediately noticeable, so eventually it didn't feel like I was going anywhere and I'll burn out. It wasn't until I knew about the importance of intensity and going to failure that I felt like the workout was beneficial. Additionally, it wasn't until I could find a reliable signal that I was going to failure properly that I can feel my brain being affected by the workout. In this case it was motion speed decreasing despite full effort. Doing all this made me see faster improvements and changes, making me actually look forward to the next session instead of seeing it as just a chore.

Another example is for when I study. I struggled a lot with memorisation, it felt like I just couldn't absorb "factual" content like biology terms, while understanding one math equation and then being able to apply it across a bunch of problems was fine. It wasn't until I knew about the concept of active recall that I can memorise things a bit more confidently. So to use a previous example, before if I had to memorise the organelles of a cell and the functions of each I'd feel completely overwhelmed and forget everything after a study session. But now if I had to do it again, I'd probably do something like this:

1. Look at list of organelles and their functions.
2. Look away and try to rewrite it in a blank page without seeing the answer.
3. If nothing comes up I deliberately pick ONE to keep in my head. For example "smooth endoplasmic reticulum."
4. If even "smooth endoplasmic reticulum" is too much I deliberately pick ONE part to remember in my head. In this case "smooth."
5. Once I am able to rewrite at least one part without looking, I slowly continue the process until my brain is able to speed up and link them together.
6. Eventually I'll be able to write in the blank paper "smooth endo...." then "smooth endoplas..." and then "smooth endoplasmic reticulum functions as..." and so on..

Doing it this way, I notice I am able to retain information much better and the process of studying feels much more rewarding. It also now feels like progress doesn't just disappear once I've done the work. Of course, I'll still need to revise, but I notice I don't start from complete scratch when I consciously do all the above.

And another final example is for eating consistently, my eating schedule used to be a complete mess until recently, it wasn't until I found oatmeal immediately freshens my mind that I go out of my way to eat something that isn't just out of complete hunger and cravings.

- **Not Feeling Overwhelmed and Choosing ONE Thing to Work On**

When making changes I was also quite overwhelmed to on where to start and it was really difficult to get started. What helped for me was using the first 30 minutes on stimulant medication to pick ONE thing to do, even if I have to mentally shut out every other possible thing I can or should work on. Eventually it'll be somewhat habitual and easier to do.

Additionally, I find that the best approach has been a holistic approach, making changes mentally, physically, and biologically at similar times rather than focusing on just one. Of course, tackling everything at the same time alone is impossible, so this is where the support of others (wherever possible) come in in my experience. But since the support of others isn't always possible, what helped me was making really easy changes that sustain themselves to eventually use as a stepping stone for other changes.

For example, taking medication was as simple as swallowing it but it made a big change, so sustaining it isn't too hard and it had big effects, so I then use that to tackle whatever the most urgent (or easiest to sustain) change is. It certainly feels like juggling plates with *a lot* of back and forth, but eventually things got better.

- **Noticing Emotional Reactions and Preventing Spirals**

One last thing I notice when building routine or making changes is catching any negative reactions such as guilt or shame and not letting it catastrophise out of control.

For example, when I was still learning how to build routine, any form of inconsistency or missed day would completely torpedo how I feel and felt like more confirmation that routine was just impossible, and even once I had support (such as medication) I notice that I still wasn't as consistent as I'd like. Doing things only started becoming much more consistent when I began reminding myself that one missed day isn't the end of the world, and that this pattern of intense negative reaction towards being inconsistent is also part of why the routine isn't sticking.

Finding Things That Personally Help

Since everyone is different what applies to me may not apply to you, so here are some things that helped me figure out personal solutions.

- **Taking Note of Anything That Even Slightly Helped Me Or I Weirdly Needed To Do**

When I was still figuring most things out I tried to keep note of what helped make me feel better. They weren't detailed, but some kind of quick and dirty note of things was beneficial.

For example, if I noticed I felt better after eating something sour, I'll write in my phone:

"sour food?"

Then I try to see if it reliably helps me or if it was just a fluke. If it was just a fluke I move on, but still keep the note around; eventually, the notes might reveal a principle or pattern that I can use that does reliably help.

- **Looking For Inspiration From New Concepts**

This one might be a bit weird and idiosyncratic. But in my experience, the typical ADHD books generally left me wanting, since most of what they had I probably already applied or didn't work well enough. So for inspiration, I tried learning of new concepts from other related fields that might help with my ADHD-adjacent issues and surprisingly for me, they did.

Probably the most relevant example is learning science. The principles of active recall and general effective learning helped me figure out what to aim for when finding approaches to learn that I can sustain. For example, even if I was able to study for only 30 minutes at a random day, as long as I did active recall, I'll be fine, I just need to rest now so I can do another 30 minute session.

Procrastination

I find that if I procrastinate intensely on something there might be something I have yet to address, since at present, with most things addressed, I don't really procrastinate as intensely even if doing some things have a 15 or 30 minute delay.

For example, previously when trying to study or do an assignment I would procrastinate a lot, and even if I did manage to force myself to do it I might either: do it in constant agony, tap out after only a brief period, or do it and burnout after, sometimes all three.

What helped me was going through a kind of checklist to see why I'm procrastinating on something, it generally looks something like this:

"Is there something I might be lacking? Did I eat? Did I sleep well? Did I drink enough water? Did I take my medication yet?"

"Does it feel unbearable to do? Is there a different way I can do it? Are there other tools and techniques that can make it easier?"

"Am I being really anxious and feel dread about it? Do I need to just sit with it for a moment and slowly but surely try to do the thing without suppressing the anxiety so my mind realises the activity is safe to do? Do I need to just calm down now since I've figured how to do it easier or since nothing else is working, is there actually a reason I'm still anxious?"

And sometimes all that's left is psyching myself up to do the thing and forcing myself to get started, be it by using music or just remembering why I wanted to do the thing in the first place.

VERY USEFUL Resources

In my experience finding quality resources is difficult and there's a lot of information out there that didn't really help me that much. Here are some resources that I've found to be immediately beneficial for ADHD and related issues, I find them to either be very clear, very scientific, very applicable, or all three.

Dr. John Kruse:

Very good resource that takes ADHD very seriously and dives into the weeds of ADHD and how different things interact with it.

https://www.youtube.com/channel/UC9DgXCGFKc_af8DiEE74FMg

Example Video(s):

Video of Dr. Kruse explaining why ADHD has no single cure yet.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=N1Ng-w417Xg>

Video of Dr. Kruse explaining how the stress hormones affect individuals with ADHD.

<https://m.youtube.com/watch?v=ugiLpu-VFGM>

Dr. Russell Barkley:

Probably *THE* guy for ADHD, basically the godfather of ADHD research. But a bit of caution, although lots of his information is very good, I found that it can make things seem very bleak.

<https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCotLWu7ljYVFPiZQfHjTMsA>

Example Video:

Video of Dr. Barkley arguing against seemingly intuitive, but ultimately misleading ideas about ADHD.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bO19LWJoZnM>

Video of Dr. Barkley explaining concept of executive functioning (which is affected heavily in people with ADHD), his videos tend to be quite long so this playlist containing the core ideas may be useful.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TBzSH-Pqhyc&list=PLKF2EqoeYbbr7Ss64oc5SggZKj-7M_as_&index=26

Dr. Scott Eilers:

Not ADHD focused, but is very helpful with the other things related to mental health and comorbidities that might be present with ADHD.

<https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCogWI9kVVvmRRPzzQBrOwzg>

Example Video:

Video of Dr. Eilers' that helped me in how to think about self-care.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=puokHeX4qvU>

Lyle McDonald:

Probably the only primary source of information relating to exercise I found extremely useful, though most of his content does focus on resistance training. His information on exercise intensity and training to failure alone has been the main thing I needed to know to exercise confidently.

Note: He can be a bit crass and dramatic, but honestly it just makes it entertaining hahahaha.

<https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCJLtThHoSMKw6rbEcyhkpQ>

Example Video(s):

Video of Mr. McDonald going into the fundamentals of a pulldown

<https://youtu.be/4vtsbe3nM6I?&t=12> <- (the first two minutes of this video in particular explains why I find him a great resource)

Video of Mr. McDonald introducing fundamental principles for training

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8ArptsIW5jI>